

THE MAN WHO REFUSES TO BE WRONG

IPL founding chairman Lalit Modi reflects on the league's evolution, arguing that **key structural compromises have capped its commercial potential**, even as valuations soar and the league tightens its grip on the global game.

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Lalit Modi is perhaps one of modern India's most conspicuous exiles. A figure who once sat at the centre of cricket's power now watches it from afar. Often seen in the United Kingdom in the company of fallen titans of Indian business, he remains as visible in absence as he once was in authority.

Exile in Modi's case has not resembled exile as history often remembers it. Unlike the near-solitary existence of those cast out before him, his life in London has remained public, even opulent. Images of that life surface often on Indian social media. His conversation with *Sportstar* took place from his home in London — seated in a plush meeting room, relaxed, punctuating his answers with regular puffs from a vape, glasses refilled with regularity.

Modi, the founding chairman of the Indian Premier League (IPL) and a key architect of its commercial rise, saw his tenure end in acrimony with his expulsion from the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI). But the distance since has done little to temper either his claims or his convictions. He now believes

the league and its franchises have left significant value unrealised because the BCCI has not adhered to what he describes as a key contractual commitment: a full home-and-away schedule.

His comments come at a time when franchise valuations continue to surge, reinforcing the IPL's position as one of the most lucrative sporting leagues in the world. Recently, two franchises, Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB) and Rajasthan Royals (RR), changed hands, underlining the growing appetite among investors for a stake in the league's expanding ecosystem. A consortium led by the Aditya Birla Group emerged as the lead bidder to acquire RCB for a reported USD 1.78 billion (approximately ₹16,700 crore), while RR was acquired by a US-based consortium led by Kal Somani for USD 1.63 billion (approximately